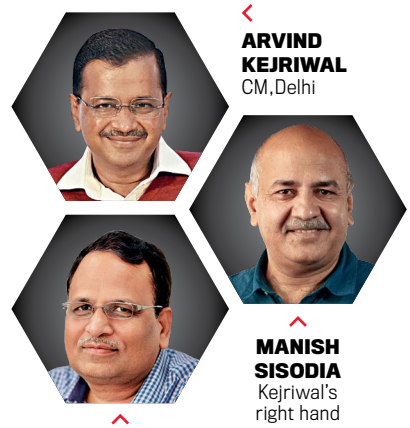
rivals in 2015. As the ministry of home affairs (MHA) sanctioned his prosecution in that case last fortnight under the Prevention of Corruption Act, Delhi politics already seemed headed for a heated summer. The arrest now seals that.

The immediate impact will be on Delhi's administration. Sisodia headed 18 of its 33 departments, including the crucial portfolios of finance, education, home, health and public works—the last three being added after Jain's arrest. A key challenge for the AAP government will come with the 2023-24 budget, due later this month. Sisodia, who has tabled eight consecutive AAP government budgets since 2015, has prepared the budget; it will now be presented by revenue minister Kailash Gahlot, who has been given charge of finance. Sisodia's budgets have been the driving force behind Kejriwal's Delhi model, which revolves around three principles—affordable healthcare and education, free electricity and water, and generation of enough revenue to fund these schemes. It's a model that has helped AAP consolidate its votebank amongst the lower and lower middle class, helping win Delhi for two consecutive terms, and one that propelled it to a win in Punjab.

Jain and Sisodia led two of the AAP government's most successful governance initiatives—in health and education. If Jain was the architect of the mohalla clinics, which provided a new model of affordable healthcare, Sisodia had turned around dilapidated government schools—thus becoming the face of a massive AAP campaign that projected him as India's "best education minister". Kejriwal will have to find talent that can fill in Sisodia's shoes—unless he plans to take charge of a bulk of the 18 departments. Gahlot, who already handled six departments, might be in legal trouble himself with an inquiry in the DTC bus procurement case. Jain's health beat has for now been given as an additional assignment



ARVIND KEJRIWAL
CM, Delhi

MANISH SISODIA
Kejriwal's right hand man, quits as deputy CM

SATYENDAR KUMAR JAIN
Has also been in jail, resigns as minister

AAP HAS A LINE READY: THAT THE BJP HAS TARGETED A DUO KNOWN FOR GOOD WORK IN HEALTH AND EDUCATION

to social welfare minister Raj Kumar Anand.

The arrests hit at the very core of Kejriwal's image—that of an anti-corruption crusader—exactly when he was set to pursue bigger ambitions. AAP was born out of the India Against Corruption agitation that had caught the nation's attention in 2011. Now, as it's itself assailed by corruption charges, rivals will have a field day. Leaked images of Jain being ministered to by a fellow Tihar inmate and conman Sukash Chandrasekhar alleging that AAP demanded bribes from him have added to the party's misery.

Kejriwal's self-projection as the only non-Congress alternative to the BJP with a pan-India appeal, which may take a hit now, had enough buyers otherwise. Successive INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation polls saw respondents back him as the Opposition

WHAT LED TO SISODIA'S ARREST

THE NEW LIQUOR POLICY

On November 17, 2021, the AAP government rolled out a new excise policy for Delhi

- Projecting a revenue increase of Rs 9,500 crore, the government decided to exit the liquor trade and leave it only to private players
- As per the policy, 849 liquor stores were to open across 32 zones in the city, each having maximum 27 liquor outlets. Earlier, four government corporations ran 475 of the city's total 864 liquor stores

VIGILANCE ACCUSATIONS AGAINST SISODIA

A July 8, 2022, vigilance report submitted by chief secretary Naresh Kumar accused deputy CM Sisodia, who headed the excise department, of crafting the policy with ulterior aims

- Sisodia, the vigilance report said, provided undue benefits to liquor vend licensees in lieu of "kickbacks" and "commissions"
- Licences were allegedly grabbed through proxy ownerships, with excise officials failing "to examine the net-worth of the bidders"
- Sisodia allegedly made key changes to the excise policy without the approval of either the L-G and the Cabinet. The arbitrary waiver of licence fee amounting to Rs 144.36 crore under the excuse of Covid-19 was allegedly done to favour the liquor cartel